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Topic Option 3: Application of a Design Innovation Method

Rethinking Social Media for Improved Creativity and Expression

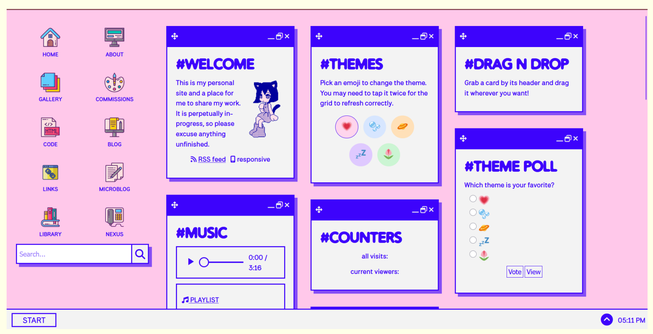
Introduction and Motivation

Social media companies have restricted user freedom, leading to homogeneous profiles, *and* allowed AI content to flood their platforms. *How can we improve choice?*

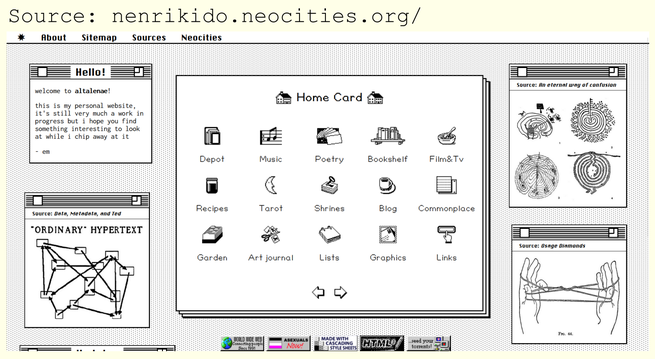
AI vs Independent Artists

82% artists think AI is a priority digital policy area (UNESCO, 2024). Concerns include:

- **Environment** – data centres damage local environments, e.g. water contamination (Fleury, 2025)
- **Plagiarism** – 74% artists (DACS, 2025) worry their work is fed to generative models.



Source: nenrikido.neocities.org/



Source: altalenae.neocities.org/

A Return to the Old Web?

Modern social media profiles are far less customisable than old websites. Now, more people are sharing personal websites on **neocities.org** every year.

Websites are complicated to make, requiring programming and hosting knowledge.

Can we create a similar, simpler platform for general users and artists?

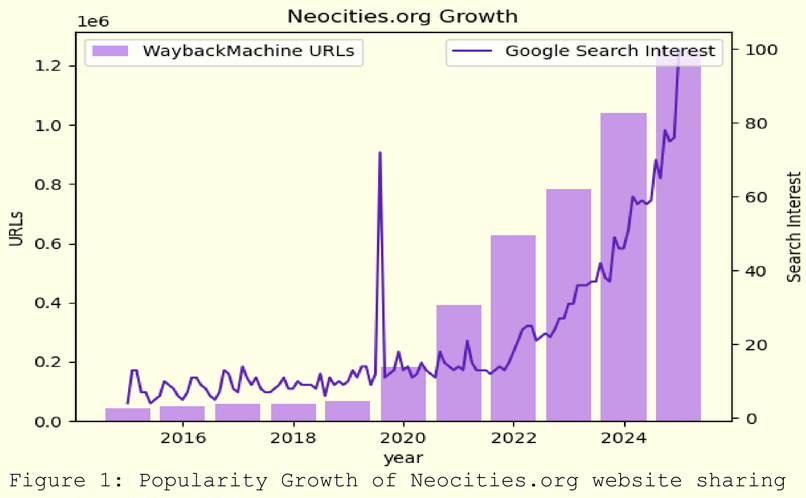
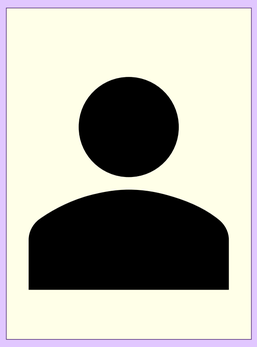


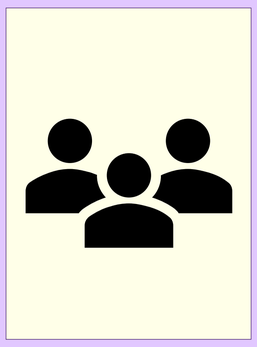
Figure 1: Popularity Growth of Neocities.org website sharing service (2015-2025)

Stakeholders

Name: Artists & Designers
Concerns:
- Avoiding Plagiarism
- Lack of artistic expression.



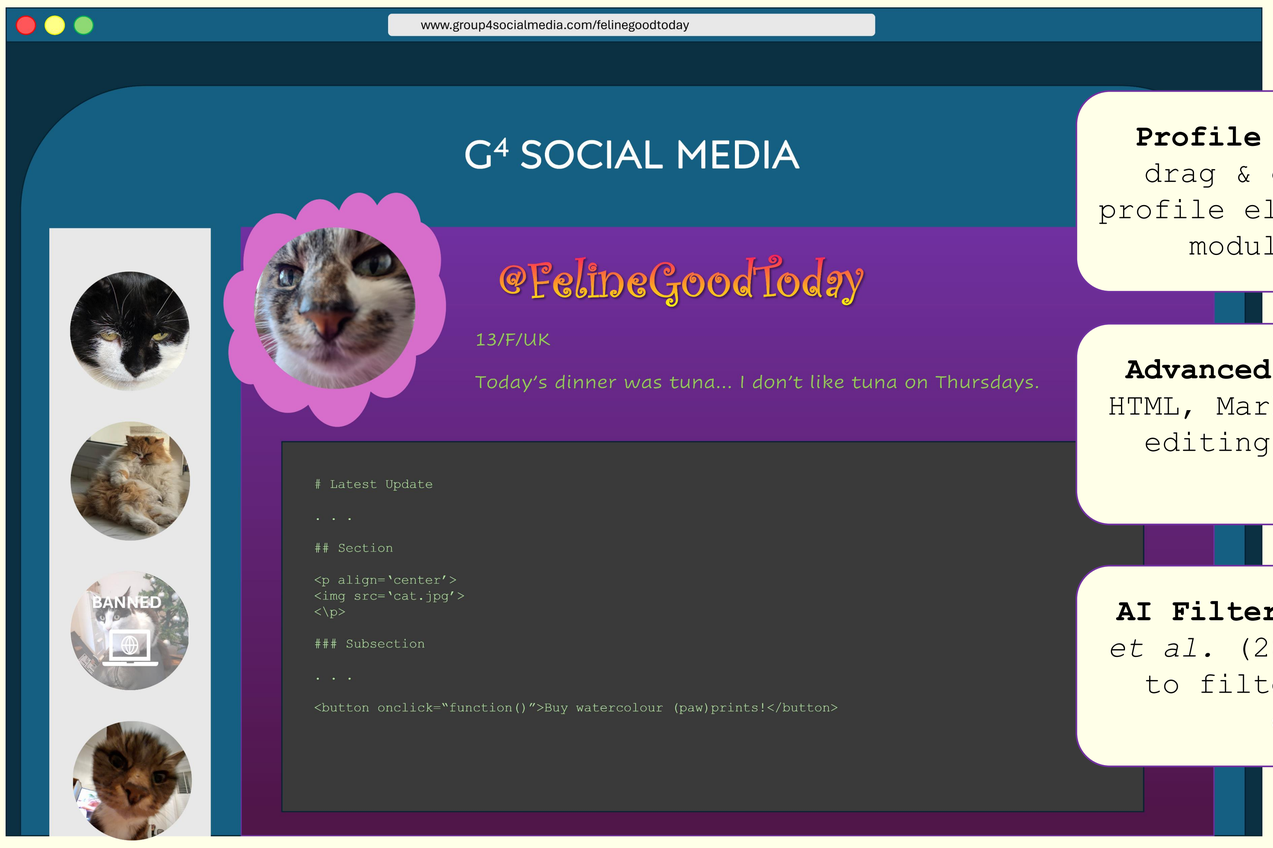
Name: Social Media Users
Concerns:
- Self-expression
- What's real vs AI?



Name: Businesses
Concerns:
- Standing out from competition and bots

Methodology and Solution

Solution: a social media platform with profile layout tools for customisation and AI content filters.



Profile Customisation – drag & drop editing of profile elements for custom modular profiles.

Advanced Customisation – HTML, Markdown, JavaScript editing for tech-savvy users.

AI Filtering – use Maraha *et al.* (2026)'s algorithms to filter AI-generated content.

Revenue Streams

- Growing social media (e.g. Meta) revenues

=> Strong growth potential.

- Advertising is the sole revenue stream; platform remains free for users.

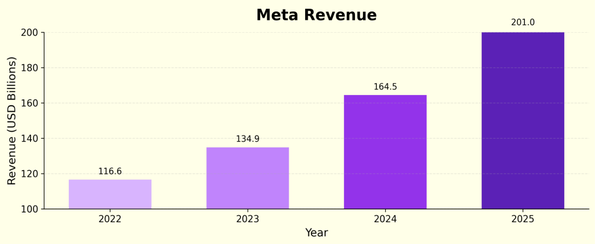


Figure 2: Social Media revenues of Meta over time (2022-2025)

Features	Benefits	Limitations
Profiles contain common features, but design is user choice	Improved customisation/ artistic self-expression	Requires more moderation Difficult desktop/mobile view support
Built-in digital art tools	Improved efficiency Encourages user engagement	Difficult implementation/maintenance
AI-filtering	Appeals to artists/ environmentalist groups	Difficult maintenance Often inaccurate

Conclusion

- Filtering AI-generated content reduces competition with bots.
- Customisation grows creativity and self-expression.